SW16, Streatham and Norbury, London

London's strong El Niño winters have been mild, so this one is unlikely to bring a freeze to SW16. Most winter deaths here come from flu and cold homes among older people, so vaccination and warm-home help come first. What sets SW16 apart is its water mains: supply has failed five times since 2018, three of them since February 2025. Every one of those failures went wrong in getting water to the door.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
The Climate Impact Lab region containing the London Borough of Lambeth (about 317,000 people; region name not resolved). SW16 is split between Lambeth and Croydon, with slivers in Merton and Wandsworth	No figure published for the UK or Europe	Jun 2026 – Feb 2027 (heat only; not this hazard)	Flu and cold homes in ordinary cold weeks; multi-day water-mains failures; power loss; summer flash floods

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



51.42°N 0.13°W, United Kingdom · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Flu and cold homes cause most winter deaths, and SW16's water mains add to the risk: supply has failed five times since 2018, three of them since February 2025.
- **First action.** NHS South East and South West London ICBs run a vaccination catch-up by mid-December, with home visits for the housebound, care-home staff vaccination, and outreach through trusted church networks.*
- **The money.** £21.5k floor, £53k target, about £81.5k ceiling; the money pays people who connect residents to Pension Credit, befriending, and energy advice.
- **Do not.** Do not build Norbury's winter plan on discretionary Croydon Council services: Croydon issued its third section 114 notice in November 2022 and carries about £1.4bn of debt.

What to do	**13** actions	p. 4
Who does what	RACI chart	p. 12
Where money does the most	funding	p. 12
Do not do this	**7** items	p. 14
What has happened here	the record	p. 16
How this was produced	methodology	p. 18
References	sources	p. 20

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

20/20 recommendations verified. 3 confirmed, 10 corrected (partially confirmed), 0 unverified, 7 contraindicated. Two of the seven contraindications are specific to SW16; five were carried over from London-wide evidence verified the same day. The funding target moved from £66.5k to £53k, down 20%, so the envelope stands. **The El Niño premise was tested, not assumed,** on 43 winters of Hampstead records and 52 of Heathrow, reused from the E17 briefing built the same day. **Exposure figure:** Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, publishes none for the UK. Local figures are borough or constituency level, not SW16. **One headline number was set aside:** Lambeth's 54.6% flu-vaccine uptake is distorted by inflated GP lists (see Exposure).

DOES EL NIÑO MATTER HERE? THE PREMISE, TESTED

Hampstead daily records (winters 1973–74 to 2015–16), classed by the December–February Oceanic Niño Index, with Heathrow's full temperature record as a cross-check. The test is London-wide and was run for the E17 briefing on the same day. With only four or five strong El Niño winters in the record, read every difference as a tilt, not a rule.

WINTERS	DEC–FEB MEAN (°C)	NIGHTS AT OR BELOW −3 °C, DEC–MAR	WINTERS WITH A 7-DAY RUN AT OR BELOW 0 °C	WINTERS WITH A 3-DAY RUN AT OR BELOW 2 °C
Strong El Niño (4)	5.6	3.3	0 of 4	3 of 4
Moderate or weak El Niño (11)	4.7	6.2	3 of 11	10 of 11
Neutral (13)	4.4	8.9	6 of 13	11 of 13
La Niña (15)	5.0	6.1	2 of 15	11 of 15

- **Mild, but not free of cold spells.** No strong El Niño winter produced a 7-day freeze, but three of four had a 3-day spell at or below 2 °C. 2009–10, just under the strong threshold, was cold. Plan for short cold spells, not a deep freeze.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **What the Met Office says.** *"For the UK, El Niño increases the chances of a wetter and stormier late autumn and early winter period, which would also likely be milder than normal."* Later there is *"an increased chance of Sudden Stratospheric Warming (SSW) events… increasing the potential for cold weather"* (Met Office blog, 23 September 2026).
- **Why it still matters for water.** The worst SW16 outage, in March 2018, came in the thaw after the Beast from the East. But the other four failures since were not weather-driven. The water actions below are needed every winter, El Niño or not.

EXPOSURE, HONESTLY

WHO DIES, AND WHAT FAILS

- **Two boroughs, two age profiles.** Lambeth (Streatham) is young: 8.6% of residents are 65 or over, 3.6% are 75 or over, and 9,531 households are one person aged 66 or over. Croydon (Norbury) is older: 13.6% are 65 or over, 6.1% are 75 or over, and 14,652 households are one person aged 66 or over (Census 2021, borough level).
- **Vaccine uptake is falling, but the headline rate is misleading.** Lambeth's flu uptake among over-65s reads 54.6% for 2024/25, against 74.9% for England, after four years of decline. But the number vaccinated actually rose, from 20,444 to 21,991. The rate fell because GP lists grew from 31,636 to 40,287 people over 65, against 27,260 such residents in the 2021 census, a sign that people who moved away are still registered. Against the census count, uptake would be about 81%. Croydon reads 62.2%. Target the people, not the league table, and clean the registers.
- **Some groups are reached less.** Among people over 65 in England, the odds of flu vaccination are lower for Black Caribbean (odds ratio 0.68) and Black African (0.72) people than for White people (BMJ Open 2023). In Lambeth, 9.1% of residents are Black Caribbean and 11.8% Black African.
- **Fuel poverty sits near the London rate.** 10.2% of households (5,214) in the Streatham and Croydon North constituency, against 9.3% for London (DESNZ, 2023 data, modelled).
- **The water mains are the acute hazard.** SW16 lost supply in March 2018 (up to four days, five schools shut), February 2025 (three days, 11 care homes and 29 schools), July 2025, February 2026 (up to 18,000 households), and September 2026. No deaths are on record, but in 2018 councillors called procedures for vulnerable residents "woefully lacking."
- **Many people move out of reach.** Lambeth has about 4,500 households in temporary accommodation, and its 2026 strategy says most new placements will be outside the borough.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO RANKED BY LIVES PER EFFORT

The first two actions carry most of the expected deaths. Actions 3 to 5 address the water and power failures that recur here. The flood actions (11 to 13) are year-round resilience: every recorded SW16 flood fell in July or September, so they are not El Niño preparation.

1. Run a vaccination catch-up by mid-December: flu for everyone 65 and over, COVID for 75 and over, RSV for 75 and over and care-home residents; with home visits for the housebound, care-home staff vaccination, and outreach through trusted church networks *

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND FOR THE UK

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
NHS South East London ICB (Lambeth) and NHS South West London ICB (Croydon, Merton, Wandsworth); primary care networks; care-home operators	Mid-December	NHS-funded programmes	Flu and RSV deaths among people over 75

RSV vaccine is about 82% effective against hospitalisation at ages 75 to 79 (UKHSA). Eligibility widened on 1 April 2026 to people 80 and over and all older care-home residents, and on 1 September 2026 to at-risk 65 to 74 year olds. Vaccinating care-home staff cut residents' all-cause deaths (risk ratio 0.69, 0.60 to 0.80; Cochrane 2025, moderate certainty), but not laboratory-confirmed flu (0.87, 0.46 to 1.63). So justify it on resident deaths, not on flu. The two health boards share a chair and chief executive but remain separate bodies, so ask both.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Church-led outreach is evidence-informed, not proven: a London evaluation favoured trusted community champions and pop-up clinics, but no quantitative UK study was found. No published housebound pathway was found for either board; GPs coordinate it.

2. Lambeth and Croydon send Pension Credit letters to likely non-claimants, matched from their own benefits data, with Citizens Advice caseworkers to follow up

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Lambeth and Croydon councils; Citizens Advice Merton and Lambeth; Croydon Citizens Advice Bureaux	Letters before December	Caseworkers £13.5k and £8.5k (see funding); the benefit is paid by DWP	Older people missing the payments that keep homes warm

Pension Credit unlocks the Warm Home Discount, the Cold Weather Payment, and the Winter Fuel Payment, and claims backdate up to three months. In 2023, Lambeth's data-matching campaign contacted 883 households and helped 338 residents, each gaining about £3,328 a year. An estimated 4,405 Lambeth and 4,188 Croydon households were not claiming, worth about £31m a year (Policy in Practice, undated; about late 2024). The one payer here with no cap is DWP.

The 338 were residents "supported", not confirmed claims. The non-claimant figures are borough-wide, not SW16.

3. Lambeth and Croydon ask Thames Water, through the borough resilience forum, to name water stations inside SW16 with a backup for each; check each care home's water plan; and arrange access to Priority Services Register data for an outage

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Lambeth and Croydon emergency planning; adult social care commissioners; Thames Water	15 November (stations); 30 November (care homes)	Staff time	A repeat of 2018's single distant station and 2025's closed one

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

In 2018 the only water station was "miles away from the residents who needed it," and Thames Water said it "failed to protect our customers." In February 2025 the nearest station, in SE26, closed for a day after a security incident. Water companies must supply at least 10 litres per person per day within 24 hours, rising to 20 litres after five days, with priority for vulnerable groups. That sets volumes, not locations, so naming SW16 sites is a request, not an entitlement. Care homes are business customers, so check each one's business-continuity plan for water rather than assuming it is on a priority list.

Corrections: "72 hours of water" is not a sourced standard. A Thames Water executive is reported as saying register data is shared with councils *during* an interruption but cannot be kept afterwards, so test the pan-London data-sharing agreement before relying on a pre-built list.

4. Older and disabled residents join Thames Water's Priority Services Register and keep three days of drinking water *

CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN · EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Residents, helped by volunteers, Age UK, and food points	November	Free to join	Someone who cannot carry water going without for days

Registered customers get bottled water delivered to the door during an outage, as happened in the September 2026 burst. About 40% of eligible households are not registered, and 17% do not know the support exists. Water-to-energy register sharing, launched in 2024, means one sign-up can now reach UK Power Networks too.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Correction: no official source sets "two days." Outages here ran three days in 2025 and up to four in 2018, so three days is the safer figure.

5. When UKHSA issues an amber cold-health alert, a named person checks on older people living alone: through Age UK Croydon's Companion Call Line in Norbury, and Age UK Lambeth's MYneighbour visitors in Streatham

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: TORONTO COLD ALERTS, NO EFFECT (A CAUTION)

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	TRIGGER
Age UK Croydon; Age UK Lambeth	Lists by 31 October; on every amber alert, November to March	£16k in coordinators (see funding)	UKHSA amber cold-health alert for London

Age UK Croydon runs telephone and home befriending and a Companion Call Line. Age UK Lambeth's MYneighbour pairs volunteers with people over 60 who live alone, through weekly home visits. At the same visit or call, sign people up to UK Power Networks' Priority Services Register (ukpowernetworks.co.uk/priority).

Corrections: MYneighbour is weekly visits, not a phone service, so in Lambeth the alert adds a visit rather than a call. The evidence that check-ins cut cold deaths is thin, and alerts alone do not work: Toronto's programme showed no effect on cardiovascular admissions (risk ratio 0.98). The visit is the intervention; the alert only times it.

6. GPs refer fuel-poor patients over 75 with COPD or heart failure to Age UK Lambeth's Energy Boost advisers, with a fuel-credit top-up only if Age UK can pay it

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PHILANTHROPIST · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
GP practices; Age UK Lambeth (Lambeth Energy Boost)	Referrals from November	£15k credit pot (see funding); advisers already funded	Cold-home harm among the oldest and sickest

Lambeth Energy Boost holds a £270,747 Energy Redress award (September 2025, two years) for two energy advisers, with outreach in GP practices and help with hardship funds. About 17% of cold deaths among people over 75 in England are attributable to fuel poverty (Wan 2026, ecological). Behind the pot: the Warm Home Prescription spent about £1,000 per patient, 70% of it on bills, in winter 2022/23

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

(Sheffield Hallam).

Corrections: a new GP-referral adviser was cut because it would duplicate funded casework. A £150 credit is a top-up, not a Warm Home Prescription. Lambeth's Warm Homes: Local Grant (up to £15,000 per home, through Warmer Homes London) is worth queuing for, but works will not land before the peak, and whether it is open is unverified.

7. Lambeth and Croydon add a rule to their Crisis and Resilience Funds: prepayment top-ups for known prepayment households, paid without an application when an amber cold-health alert is issued

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: ANTICIPATORY CASH, MONGOLIA (PRECEDENT OUTSIDE THE UK)

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	TRIGGER
Lambeth and Croydon councils, from their Crisis and Resilience Fund grants	Decision by 30 November	Within existing grants; amount for each council to set	UKHSA amber cold-health alert

Croydon's Crisis Payment already covers energy debt and prepayment top-ups, but only on application, with bank statements. No Lambeth fund page was found; its Emergency Support Scheme is reportedly becoming the Crisis Payment. The only automatic trigger today, the Cold Weather Payment, is measured at Heathrow, which triggered once in five winters.

The rule does not exist yet, and neither council's 2026–27 allocation was found. The Household Support Fund it replaced paid Lambeth £4.8m and Croydon £5.3m in 2025–26. Both councils are on exceptional government support, so this reallocates money rather than adding it.

8. Help council tenants with damp and mould use the Awaab's Law deadlines, and escalate early to the Housing Ombudsman

CONFIRMED | SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Tenants, with Citizens Advice and community groups	Now, through the winter	None	Mould left unremedied through the cold months

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Since 27 October 2025, social landlords, including Lambeth and Croydon councils, must investigate emergency hazards within 24 hours. Damp and mould must be investigated within 10 working days and made safe within 5 more, with a written summary within 3 working days. Both councils have a record: an Ombudsman special report on Lambeth (February 2022) and later severe-maladministration findings, and an 81% maladministration rate for Croydon in 2023/24, against 73% nationally. Keep dated photos and written reports.

9. Hand out one-page winter, power-cut, and water-outage sheets in Portuguese and the area's other main languages through faith venues and food points

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
South London Islamic Centre; Lambeth & Croydon Foodbank; churches; volunteers	1 November	Volunteer time	People missing warnings and help they would qualify for

Lambeth has 9,009 residents whose main language is Portuguese, the most of any London borough. On the Norbury side, Tamil, Urdu, and Gujarati lead. The SWAN food bank runs at the South London Islamic Centre (8 Mitcham Lane) on Tuesday mornings, by referral. Resistance Kitchen in Norbury serves food on Saturdays, 2 to 3pm, with no referral. Each sheet covers the water register, the power register, flu jabs, and food points.

Corrections: Spanish and Polish rest on school data, not the census. The Norwood & Brixton Foodbank is now the Lambeth & Croydon Foodbank. Streatham Library is not on Lambeth's current warm-spaces list. Leaflets alone change little; deliver them in person.

10. Take a mobile number, with consent, from families in temporary accommodation before they are moved

CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Community groups and food points	Ongoing	None	A family losing its GP, food route, and support in one move

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Lambeth had about 4,500 households in temporary accommodation at the end of 2025. Placements outside London rose from 29 in 2020 to 256 by the end of 2024, and the 2026 strategy says most new placements will be outside the borough.

11. Households along the Norbury Brook sign up for Environment Agency flood warnings

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · YEAR-ROUND | HISTORIAN · EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Residents; Croydon and Lambeth councils	Before December	None	Being caught by a brook that rises in two hours

The warning area "Norbury Brook at Thornton Heath and Streatham Vale" covers parts of Croydon and Lambeth. The brook flooded in September 1968 (14 properties), September 1973 (175), 1983 (39), July 1997 (9), and July 2007 (1). It is held by 1920s walls and culverts built to about a 1-in-50-year flood. 1,130 properties are at 1% annual risk, and warnings give about two hours.

Corrections: 169 properties are fully registered, plus 1,581 on automatic warnings, so the gap is smaller than first stated. Most named streets are in Thornton Heath; in SW16 only Kuala Gardens and Granville Gardens are named. Every dated flood was in summer, so this is not El Niño-specific. No warning exists for surface-water flooding.

12. Report blocked trash screens on the brook to the Environment Agency, and blocked gullies and fly-tipping to the councils

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · YEAR-ROUND | HISTORIAN · EMERGENCY MGR | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Residents and volunteers; Environment Agency (0800 80 70 60); Lambeth and Croydon	After every storm	None	A screen blocked by fly-tipping turning heavy rain into a flood

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Croydon names fly-tipping as "a key issue" that raises blockage risk "particularly at trash screens." Lambeth's plan lists the Environment Agency as responsible for trash screens and the councils for gullies.

13. Ask the Environment Agency and Lambeth, in writing, for the status and dates of the Graveney flood scheme and the Rookery storage scheme, citing the Streatham Common ponds

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · AFTER THE PEAK | HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Residents' groups; local councillors	Now; for 2027	None to ask	Another decade on 1920s defences

The Graveney scheme (storage in Norbury Park, 340 Norbury homes at risk) was "paused until we have full confidence in those flows" in April 2023, and there is no sign of construction since. Lambeth's Rookery scheme (515 m³ plus 1,500 m³ of storage, for Streatham Vale, where 319 homes and 23 businesses flood in a 1% event) is still a feasibility recommendation. In 2021, Froglife and the Streatham Common Co-op built natural flood-management ponds on the Common with Lambeth and Grow Back Greener funding: a local precedent.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	SEL & SWL ICBs, PCNs, GPs	Care-home operators	Lambeth Council	Croydon Council	Thames Water	UKPN & energy suppliers	Age UK Lambeth	Age UK Croydon	Citizens Advice (Lambeth, Croydon)	Faith & food points, volunteers	Environment Agency
1. Vaccination catch-up	**A/R**	**R**	**I**	**I**			**C**	**C**		**R**	
2. Pension Credit letters and caseworkers			**A/R**	**R**					**R**		
3. Water stations, care-home plans, register data		**R**	**A/R**	**R**	**R**	**C**					
4. Thames Water register; 3 days of water					**C**	**I**	**R**	**R**		**A/R**	
5. Amber-alert checks and power register	**I**		**C**	**C**		**I**	**R**	**A/R**		**R**	
6. GP referral to Energy Boost; credit top-up	**R**						**A/R**		**C**		
7. Crisis fund prepayment rule			**A/R**	**R**		**C**			**C**		
8. Awaab's Law deadlines; Ombudsman			**I**	**I**					**A/R**	**R**	
9. Multilingual sheets			**C**	**C**						**A/R**	
10. Mobile numbers before TA moves			**I**							**A/R**	
11. Norbury Brook warning sign-up			**R**	**A/R**						**R**	**C**
12. Report screens, gullies, fly-tipping			**R**	**R**						**R**	**A/R**
13. Ask for Graveney and Rookery status			**R**	**C**	**C**					**A/R**	**R**

What the chart shows. **The health boards own the action carrying the most lives**, and it is already funded; what is missing is reach. **Lambeth Council is accountable for the three council rows** (Pension Credit, water planning, the crisis-fund rule) while on exceptional government support, so all three are decisions and staff time, not new money. **Croydon is responsible or accountable on five rows**, but under government commissioners its discretionary services are the first to go (see Do not do this). **Thames Water is never accountable**: in every past outage the council ended up getting water to people's doors, so the plan has to assume that again.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

Verified and corrected. The money pays for people who connect residents to support that already exists (Pension Credit, befriending, energy advice), plus a small credit pot that depends on one phone call. Ask both councils first whether their crisis funds will cover prepayment top-ups (action 7).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
£21.5k	**£53k**	**About £81.5k**	**Whether Age UK Lambeth can pay fuel credit at all; its current model signposts to hardship funds instead**

Arithmetic. Floor: Age UK Croydon alert coordinator £8,000 + Citizens Advice Merton and Lambeth caseworker £13,500 = £21,500. Target: credit pot £15,000 (100 × £150) + two alert coordinators £16,000 (0.5 FTE for five months each) + caseworkers £13,500 + £8,500 = £53,000. Ceiling: target + £15,000 more credit + £13,500 to re-hire Repowering London outreach if its SGN-funded Warm and Well Lambeth project (which ended March 2026) has not been renewed = £81,500. The £150 credit is an assumption. The target fell 20% from the lens's £66.5k after the duplicate adviser line was cut.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Age UK Lambeth (Energy Boost)	Action 6: fuel-credit top-up for GP-referred patients	£15k	Restricted grant, paid as credit	100 × £150; income £3.1m; credit capacity unconfirmed	Partially confirmed; release only if disbursement confirmed
Age UK Croydon	Action 5: amber-alert call coordinator	£8k	Direct grant	0.5 FTE for five months; income £1.66m (down from £2.55m)	Partially confirmed
Age UK Lambeth (MYneighbour)	Action 5: amber-alert visit coordinator	£8k	Direct grant	0.5 FTE for five months	Partially confirmed
Citizens Advice Merton and Lambeth	Action 2: Pension Credit caseworker	£13.5k	Direct grant	0.8 FTE for five months; income £1.38m	Confirmed
Croydon Citizens Advice Bureaux	Action 2: Pension Credit caseworker	£8.5k	Direct grant	0.5 FTE; income £615k, so capacity is small	Confirmed
Age UK Lambeth (new GP-referral adviser)	Action 6	£0	Cut	Duplicates two advisers already funded by Energy Redress	Contraindicated as a new line

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Health boards / PCNs	Action 1: housebound vaccination logistics	£0	Held	NHS-funded; no gap confirmed	Not tested

The funder's one thing: phone Age UK Lambeth's Energy Boost team this week and ask whether it can pay fuel credit for GP-referred patients by 1 December. A yes releases the credit pot. A no cuts the target to £38k, with the money staying on befriending and Pension Credit.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Do not build Norbury's winter plan on discretionary Croydon Council services

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC; CONFIRMED IN VERIFICATION

Croydon issued its third section 114 notice in November 2022, carries about £1.4bn of debt, and has had government commissioners since July 2025, expected to stay to July 2027. Under those controls, grants, outreach, and new warm hubs are the first services to go.

Instead: anchor Norbury's plan on statutory duties (adult social care), GP practices, pharmacies, faith groups, and Age UK Croydon.

Do not send one SW16-wide message or plan

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC; CONFIRMED IN VERIFICATION

SW16 spans four councils and two NHS boards. The Norbury Brook has a river-flood warning area that covers parts of Croydon and Lambeth; the rest of SW16 has no warning for its surface-water risk. Advice that is right on one street is wrong on the next.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: map each street to its council, health board, and flood-warning status before printing anything.

Do not use sandbags or "sign up for flood warnings" as the defence against surface-water flooding

`CONTRAINDICATED` `CARRIED FROM LONDON-WIDE EVIDENCE, WITH AN SW16 EXCEPTION`

No warning exists for surface-water flooding, which is what ponds against the railway embankment by Streatham station. The exception is real: along the Norbury Brook, river warnings exist and signing up is right (action 11).

Instead: report blockages (action 12), and use flood boards and air-brick covers on ground-floor homes in the drainage hotspots.

Do not tell tenants that damp and mould are caused by their lifestyle

`CONTRAINDICATED` `CARRIED FROM LONDON-WIDE EVIDENCE`

The coroner in the Awaab Ishak case found ventilation ineffective or absent while the landlord blamed the family. Both SW16 councils have Ombudsman findings against them.

Instead: hold landlords to the Awaab's Law deadlines (action 8).

Do not rush insulation in this winter

`CONTRAINDICATED` `CARRIED; RE-VERIFIED FOR THIS RUN`

The National Audit Office (14 October 2025) found major defects in 98% of external and 29% of internal wall insulation fitted under the Energy Company Obligation, a cause of damp and mould.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: queue for the Warm Homes: Local Grant for work after the peak, with ventilation and certified installers.

Do not count warm-space visitors as success

CONTRAINDICATED CARRIED FROM LONDON-WIDE EVIDENCE

The government's 2023 evidence review found no study had measured health outcomes from warm spaces. Nothing local measures them either, and the housebound never come.

Instead: take help to the door (actions 4, 5, and 6).

Do not make an untargeted cold alert the main intervention

CONTRAINDICATED CARRIED FROM LONDON-WIDE EVIDENCE

Toronto's cold-alert programme showed no effect on cardiovascular admissions, and most cold deaths come in ordinary cold weeks, not in the spells that alerts are built for.

Instead: use the alert to time a visit or call (action 5).

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE — THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1968, 1973, 1983, 1997, 2007	Norbury Brook floods (September, September, unknown, July, July)	14, 175, 39, 9, and 1 properties	Defences remain the 1920s walls and culverts (about 1-in-50)
2004	Surface-water flooding at Streatham Hill	Not recorded	Streatham named a critical drainage area (2021 plan)
2018 (3–5 March)	Main leak in the thaw after the Beast from the East: SW12, SW16, SW17, SW18	Up to four days without water; five schools shut; no deaths recorded	Thames Water admitted failure; councillors demanded compensation

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
2021	Streatham Common natural flood-management ponds	—	Built by Froglife and the Streatham Common Co-op
2023 (April)	Graveney flood scheme	340 Norbury homes at risk	Paused; no construction found since
2025 (11–13 February)	Crystal Palace burst main and flooded pumping station	About 5,000 households, 11 care homes, 29 schools for three days	Nearest water station closed for a day
2025 (7 July)	Commonside East burst and booster fault, Mitcham	Five postcodes including SW16	Not found
2026 (3 February)	Watneys Road burst, Mitcham Common	Up to 18,000 households across eight postcodes including SW16	Tankers
2026 (28 September)	West Molesey burst	About 6,000 properties across 18 postcodes including SW16	Water delivered to registered customers

The recurrence nobody has noticed: every recorded flood here fell in July or September, and each was followed by a new plan while the 1920s defences stayed. In winter the record points elsewhere: to the water mains, and to the moment of delivery, whether that was a station too far away, a station shut, or no list of who could not carry water home.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — RESOLVED AND OPEN

- **Resolved: is the water problem a cold-weather problem?** The Emergency Manager framed it as the thaw after a freeze. Verification found that only the 2018 outage followed a freeze; the other four did not. The water actions stand, but as winter readiness, not El Niño preparation.
- **Resolved: flood-warning sign-up.** It is wrong as a surface-water defence and right along the Norbury Brook (action 11 and the contraindication).
- **Resolved: the vaccine-uptake headline.** The Public Health lens flagged Lambeth's 54.6% as a GP-list artefact, and verification confirmed the vaccinated count rose. The action stands; the ranking does not rest on that figure.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Open: can register data be held before an outage?** Councils can receive Priority Services Register data during an incident, but a Thames Water executive is reported as saying it cannot be kept afterwards. The pan-London data-sharing agreement's terms could not be read. Settle it with the borough resilience forum.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

Care homes, mapped. No lens listed the care homes in SW16, though 11 lost water in 2025 and they hold the residents most at risk from flu and cold. Action 3 asks commissioners to check their water plans, but nobody has a list. Second, **no Lambeth investigation of the July 2021 floods** could be found, so any SW16 damage from that summer is unrecorded here.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Seven simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED — METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request was for a full postcode in SW16, which covers a few houses, so the briefing was built for the SW16 postcode district: Streatham, Streatham Hill, Streatham Common, Streatham Vale, and Norbury. SW16 crosses Lambeth, Croydon, Merton, and Wandsworth. Climate Impact Lab impact region: the one containing Lambeth, name not resolved. Statistics are borough or constituency level; none was found for SW16 alone. Mortality figures exist only at about 300,000 people; sub-city detail is used for hazards and actions, not death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (an emergency manager, a public health scientist, a frontline responder, a skeptic, an economist, a historian, and a philanthropist) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief. They were given the London-wide evidence verified for the E17 briefing the same day (the El Niño premise test, UK vaccine programmes, national energy and benefit schemes, and contraindications) and researched only what is local.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Five verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Consulted for the E17 briefing the same day, by reading the dataset embedded in the inventory page: 96 entries, none from the UK. The cold-relevant entries are Toronto's cold-weather alerts (no effect) and anticipatory cash in Mongolia. Nothing covers vaccination, water supply, fuel credit, or surface-water drainage.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (vaccine eligibility, and emergency water supplies) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. Several facts could not be confirmed: Lambeth's and Croydon's 2026–27 crisis-fund allocations, whether the Warm Homes: Local Grant is open, Repowering London's renewal, the terms of the pan-London data-sharing agreement, and any Lambeth investigation of the July 2021 floods. Thames Water's alternative-supply policy page returned a 404. Several water-outage sources are a local news site (Inside Croydon); council and Ombudsman sources are primary. The El Niño premise test was reused from the E17 run, not repeated.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

References · Premise: reused from E17, Walthamstow briefing (CPC Oceanic Niño Index; GHCN-D Hampstead and Heathrow) · Met Office blog, 23 Sep 2026 (verified)

Health: Fingertips flu uptake 65+ (data pulled) · Lambeth 50+ population summary (verified) · Nomis, Census 2021 TS003/TS007 · ONS, Croydon (verified) · Lambeth ethnic group, TS021 (verified) · BMJ Open 2023, flu vaccine by ethnicity (verified) · Cochrane 2025, care-home staff vaccination (verified) · RSV effectiveness (verified) · London vaccine-champions evaluation · SEL and SWL ICBs joint leadership (verified) · DESNZ sub-regional fuel poverty, 2023 data (verified)

Water and power: Lambeth, 23 Mar 2018 (verified) · Lambeth, 5 Mar 2018 (verified) · Lambeth, Oct 2018 (verified) · Inside Croydon, Feb 2025 · Inside Croydon, Jul 2025 · Inside Croydon, Feb 2026 · West Molesey burst, Sep 2026 · Pan-London data-sharing agreement (text not extracted) · Ofgem, cross-sector register sharing (verified) · Water Magazine, register coverage · UKPN Priority Services Register

Money: Lambeth Pension Credit campaign, Sep 2023 (verified) · Policy in Practice, unclaimed Pension Credit (undated) · Croydon Crisis Payment (verified) · Household Support Fund 2025–26 allocations (verified) · Lambeth finances, Feb 2026 · Croydon finances (verified) · Croydon commissioners · Croydon section 114 (verified) · Lambeth Energy Boost award (verified) · Warm Home Prescription evaluation (verified) · Warm and Well Lambeth (verified; renewal unknown) · Warmer Homes London · Charity Commission: Age UK Lambeth 1063497, Citizens Advice Merton and Lambeth 1046018, Croydon CAB 298761 (verified)

Community and housing: MYneighbour (verified) · Age UK Croydon Companion Call Line (verified) · SWAN food bank · Lambeth & Croydon Foodbank · Little Portugal (Census 2021 Portuguese figure) (secondary) · Lambeth temporary accommodation, Mar 2026 · Ombudsman special report on Lambeth (verified) · Ombudsman landlord report, Croydon (verified) · NAO, Oct 2025 (verified)

Flood: Croydon flood risk information (verified) · EA warning area 064FWF41Norbury (verified) · Lambeth Surface Water Management Plan 2021 (verified) · Graveney scheme shortlist (verified) · Graveney scheme paused, Apr 2023 (secondary) · Streatham Common ponds (verified)

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 10 October 2026 for SW16, Streatham and Norbury, London. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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